

Abdullah THE THIRD

A fractured verdict translates into a 3G networking success as Rahul's preferred man gets the top job

By Ramesh Vinayak

By conventional reckoning, the Jammu and Kashmir election result is a mirror-image of the previous one in 2002, a hung House and no clear winner in the 87-member Assembly. Yet, the polls reflect the new ground realities with wider ramifications for both the troubled state and the nation. The verdict catapulted the third generation of the most influential Kashmiri family—the Abdullahs—into power six years after being dethroned. More importantly, it handed India a huge diplomatic edge vis-a-vis Pakistan amid the deepening chill over the Mumbai attacks.

The elections in the state had never been so popular and peaceful with a 61 per cent voter turnout despite boycott calls by separatists. However, the absence of fear of militants coupled with the mainstream parties' deft strategy of delinking the elections from the larger Kashmir imbroglio did the trick this time.

While the timing of the elections could not have been more opportune in lending weight to Delhi's diplomatic offensive against Pakistan, the ruling Congress has political reasons to rejoice, too. The split mandate unexpectedly translated into major gains for the party despite its below par performance of winning only 17 seats—three less than last time. The results not only turned the Congress into a

ELECTION RESULTS

2008	
PARTY	SEATS WON
NC	28
PDP	21
Congress	17
BJP	11
Others	10
2002	
NC	28
PDP	16
Congress	20
BJP	1
Others	22

(TOTAL NUMBER OF SEATS: 87)

kingmaker, but also pitched the party into a power-sharing alliance with the National Conference (NC) which emerged as the single largest party winning 28 seats.

Together, the NC and the Congress have 45 MLAs, one more than magic figure of 44 required to form the government. The alliance also nets NC, a partner in the NDA, into the UPA. Although the NC's seat tally remained the same as 2002, the party was quick to stake claim to power with its President Omar Abdullah plumping for Congress support, glossing over the fact that the past NC-Congress

alliances were unmitigated political disasters, particularly the Rajiv Gandhi-Farooq Abdullah accord before the 1987 elections that pushed the state into militancy.

The fractured verdict also necessitated the charismatic Abdullah Senior, who was projected as the party's chief ministerial candidate, to step aside and pass the baton to his only son—a smooth succession to the third generation of the Abdullah clan which has ruled the state for much of the last six decades. Farooq said that he will work to strengthen the party base, while his son would run the gov-

